

Taxiing for Take-off

Competition in the Indian skies is set to become even more cut-throat as Akasa Air and Jet Airways prepare for launch of their commercial services

BY MANISH PANT

► **AN INTENSE BATTLE** for market share in the world's third-largest domestic aviation market is brewing. Competition is set to intensify as the market gets ready to welcome two more players—low-cost carrier (LCC) Akasa Air, which is set to commence operations in July; and the re-launch of Jet Airways later this year.

Recently, Rakesh Jhunjhunwala-promoted Akasa released the first look of its Boeing 737 MAX aircraft. With the lowest seat-mile cost for a single-aisle airplane and high dispatch reliability, the Boeing 737 MAX may provide Akasa with a competitive edge.

“Today, passengers seek environmentally friendly options to travel, and Akasa is proud to be an environ-

mentally friendly airline with the youngest and greenest fleet in global aviation,” Co-founder and CEO Vinay Dube tells *Business Today*.

The airline's scheduled launch in June was postponed by a month due to a delay in the delivery of its first aircraft, which will happen by mid-June. Akasa says this won't affect its plans to induct 18 aircraft by March 2023. Next on Dube's agenda is to obtain the Air Operator's Certificate (AOC) after fulfilling all regulatory requirements laid down by aviation regulator Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA).

Akasa has partnered with US-based reservation systems provider Navitaire to implement its tech-enabled strategy. “While pricing is important, it is not the only differentiator. Compared to current industry standards, we plan to adopt a more progressive approach in our use of technology and data analytics. That starts from the way a customer books a ticket, the payment experience, or in how we service our

**RAKESH
JHUNJHUNWALA-
PROMOTED
AKASA AIR IS
SET TO LAUNCH
COMMERCIAL
OPERATIONS IN
JULY 2022**



PHOTO COURTESY BY **AKASA AIR**